There once was a lady named Bright
who traveled much faster than light.
She departed one day in a relative way
and came home the previous night.

With Roman's comment and the famous limerick to goad us, we easily figured out how to construct a time machine using two wormholes that move at high speeds relative to each other.[8] (I shall not describe that time machine here, because it is a bit complicated and there is a simpler, more easily described time machine to which I shall come shortly.)

I am a loner; I like to retreat to the mountains or an isolated seacoast, or even just into an attic, and think. New ideas come slowly and require large blocks of quiet, undisturbed time to gestate; and most worthwhile calculations require days or weeks of intense, steady concentration. A phone call at the wrong moment can knock my concentration off balance, setting me back by hours. So I hide from the world.

But hiding for too long is dangerous. I need, from time to time, the needle-pricking stimulus of conversations with people whose viewpoints and expertise are different from mine.

In this chapter thus far I have described three examples. Without Carl Sagan's phone call and the challenge to make his novel scientifically correct, I would never have ventured into research on wormholes and time machines. Without Don Page's letter, Mike Morris and I would not have known that all wormholes, regardless of their shape, require exotic material to keep them open. And without Tom Roman's remark, Morris and I might have gone on blithely unaware that from wormholes an advanced civilization can easily make a time machine.

In the pages to come, I will describe other examples of the crucial role of needle-pricking interactions. However, not *all* ideas arise that way. Some arise from introspection. June 1987 was a case in point.

In early June 1987, emerging from several months of frenetic classroom teaching and interactions with my research group and the LIGO team, I retreated, exhausted, into isolation.

All spring long something had been gnawing at me, and I had been trying to ignore it, waiting for some days of quiet, to ponder. Those days, at